

DISEASES

Plant diseases are caused by viruses, fungi, or bacteria. They are often more difficult to prevent and contain than pests; they can be spread by spores in the air, rainwater splash, animals and insects, and also by poor garden hygiene. Diseases vary in severity—some are fairly superficial and can be treated, while others are severe enough to cause the plant to die (see growing guides for specific information and advice).

PREVENTION

- Rotate your crops to prevent a buildup of diseases in the soil.
- Seedlings and young plants are especially vulnerable to the microorganisms that are sometimes present in stored water. Instead, use tap water while plants are young.
- Give crops plenty of space so that air can circulate freely around and between them.
- Destroy any diseased plant matter that you remove—do not compost it, since this risks further contamination.
- Keep your plants strong and healthy with regular feeding, watering, and weeding.
- When pruning fruit trees,



Gray mold coats and rots crops.

remove diseased or dead material immediately. Be careful not to tear the wood, since this creates an open wound through which diseases might enter.

- Make sure that you clean and sterilize your tools and equipment regularly. If you use a greenhouse or potting shed, keep it clean and ventilated—diseases will reproduce rapidly in warm, wet, stagnant conditions.

TREATMENT

- Some fungal diseases are preventable with fungicides, but these may not be effective if the disease has already taken hold. Plants with bacterial infections may survive if diseased plant parts are removed quickly, but a plant with a viral disease should be removed and destroyed.